

Much Ado About Postpartum Depression
Or: A epistolary exploration of postpartum depression from the perspective of Hero
Leonato from Shakespeare's *Much Ado About Nothing*

Dearest friend,

There was a star that danced, and under that was my cousin born. But on the night of my own entrance, I fear that star did fall. For what else could foretell this strange, twin tale of joy and woe, where one cousin finds peace in what she never sought, and the other, having wished for it all, meets only woe. I beseech thee, listen closely to my mournful fate, read the truth in my words before it is too late.

I am Hero, wife of Claudio of Florence and Daughter of Leonato of Messina— oh, dear Messina! How I miss that orchard of naive girlhood! Her name hath not crossed my lips since my departure, for fear I would shed unwilling tears. My Messina is worth a thousand times this sweeping city, though truthfully it holds beauty that I just cannot adore. My cousin, Beatrice, also newly wed, oft writes of her joyous adventures exploring her new Paduan clime, whereas I am nothing but overwhelmed in this new abode of mine! Wherefore can I not see the world through her eyes?

T'was easy to feign excitement as I wrote to my dear cousin, but in the flesh, impossible to convince my husband of my love— for his estate, that is, when inside I boiled with naught but hate. For as that hate took root deep within me, it distended my belly and filled it with sorrow. My husband swore my melancholy moods would fade away: "In but nine moons," that gent did claim, "You shall cry no longer, you will be gripped by that everlasting joy of our creation!" But at that hour of deliverance, I still cried, in harmony with that newly arrived babe. We wept of this cold, unforgiving world, so unlike that warm, comforting womb, that citrus summer garden from which we fell.

Three moons since, joy in my heart her countenance cannot provoke. This babe feels strange and foreign to me, more than even my own sorrow. My maids would often find me pacing my chambers, with sorrows that could not escape me but with a wail: "No child of mine is she!" But one night, t'was my husband Claudio, not a maid, who happened upon me as I cried, and his soul was set ablaze. "What, unfaithful Hero? Nay issue of ours? Then of whose?" I swore, till the sun rose he gripped me shouting, "Out on thee, seeming! You seem to me as Dian in her orb, as chaste as is the bud ere it be blown. But you are more intemperate in your blood than Venus!" ¹Yet, the maids did whisper to the cooks of the tempestuous haste with which he left my chambers under

¹ This is a direct line from the original play, delivered by Claudio to Hero in what I imagine was a traumatic scene for her, as it led to her faking her death and almost being cast out by her family.

moonlight, so is this fear but something constructed by my pleading mind? It must be so, twas only his voice which remained with me! Oh woe, for the child that hath no mother, oh woe, for the husband whose mistress' mind hath fled! I know not why evil thoughts chase out my maternal spirit, why compassionate womanhood curdles, leaving madness to supplant it!

I did wish in those early days to tell my cousin Beatrice, but could not bid myself to write of it. But oh, joyous day, when her letter announced a visit to our estate! I resolved myself to share my turn of fate upon her arrival.

At her welcome banquet, she and I danced and danced till our feet bid us they could do no more. Of that happy time, one thing remained amiss- the heavy cloud that was my husband's sullenness. Beatrice's eyes betrayed her worry, and I did pull her aside to halt her protestations. Later, I swore, I would explain- in the southern garden at midnight, away from prying eyes and ears. But let us first have this joyous night!

When I later did approach the gardens, I caught an exchange of those cruel, loving ripostes betwixt her and her husband.

"I wonder why your tongue doth run nonstop this eve."

"I must make myself known before this damned curse's deliverance, when I become outnumbered!"

Whatever could he mean? I used the shadows of the night to conceal my prying ears.

"Better to pray *silently*, that after deliverance, two Beatrices shall not plague you!" My cousin doth proclaim.

"Two Beatrices! So you think it shall be a girl? My beloved, I thank the gods everyday that there is only one of you to abuse me. They must not send a daughter, for a son I could perhaps sway to my cause. A daughter... well, better to deliver me to my grave anon!"

My own visage hath grown hot, as that gent did place a hand on her abdomen- how could I have missed that rounded bump?

"Not to worry my beloved, the kicks are quite weak. I am sure then, it is a son. How lovely it is that our young one takes after his father!"

“Oh you crude, hateful woman” he laughed, pulling my cousin in for a kiss, but she held him fast:

“Though thinketh to silence me with such ease? And yet, my cousin shall soon draw near, so silenced I must be. I fear something truly dire, I can see it from her fair complexion and in Claudio’s ire. I trust you will leave, and share not our joyous news until their spirits rise?

He departed, and I retreated hence. How selfish am I, to tarnish my cousin’s blossoming joy with misplaced laments! I bid my throat, swallow these secret woes, be the loving mother, dutiful wife— or else perform the show. For when the sun doth shine, I’ll not declare how fiercely I feel the burn that scorches air. So I confide in you, your solace is my plea— lest silent stars alone bear witness to me.